



10 The HL essay: independent literary analysis (HL)

Individual assessment · IB Diploma · Concept guide and original exam-style practice

Understand the concept

The HL essay is an independent, externally assessed piece of literary analysis (approximately 1200–1500 words) on a self-chosen line of inquiry into one work or a small set of works studied. It requires students to formulate their own focused research question and sustain an original argument, demonstrating independent critical thinking rather than responding to a question set by an examiner. A precise, arguable line of inquiry — not a broad topic — is essential to success.

Worked example: follow the reasoning

A broad, weak topic: 'Family relationships in the work.' A refined HL essay line of inquiry: 'How does the author use shifts in domestic space (rooms, thresholds, doorways) to mark changing power dynamics within one family across the work?' The refined version is specific, arguable, and tied to a concrete textual feature (spatial imagery), which supports sustained, focused analysis rather than a broad thematic survey.

Quick check · multiple choice

A strong HL essay line of inquiry should be:

- A As broad as possible to allow maximum flexibility
- B Narrow, specific, and arguable, tied to a concrete textual feature or technique
- C Identical to a past Paper 2 essay question
- D Focused only on biographical facts about the author

Write your choice: _____

Structured practice

Answer in the space provided.

- 1 Propose and briefly justify a possible HL essay line of inquiry for a generic novel [10]
involving an unreliable narrator and a recurring motif of mirrors. Explain why your proposed question is sufficiently narrow and arguable for an independent essay.

Final answer: _____



Answers and explanation

Question 1 [10]

- Proposed line of inquiry: 'How does the recurring motif of mirrors function to expose or destabilise the reliability of the narrator's self-perception?'
- Justification point 1: the question is tied to a specific, traceable textual feature (mirror motif) rather than a broad theme, allowing focused close reading.
- Justification point 2: it is arguable — a case could be made that mirrors reveal self-deception, or alternatively that they reveal moments of rare self-awareness, giving room for a genuine thesis.
- Justification point 3: it connects a technique (motif) to a broader critical concept (narrator reliability), satisfying the HL essay's expectation of independent critical insight.
- Note: caution against restating plot; the essay must analyse how the motif functions, not simply where mirrors appear.

Quick check answer

B. Precision and arguability allow for sustained, focused independent analysis within the word limit.

Self-assessment

Compare each credited step with your own answer. Fix the first reasoning or content error, then retry the practice question without looking at the solution.

Based on the IB English A: Literature guide (2019).

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